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1. SETUP & INTERFACE BASICS

Before you cut a single clip, you need to understand the workspace. Premiere Pro is modular, meaning you can move windows around, but the default "Editing" workspace is best for beginners.

A. The Main Panels (Windows):

The Project Panel (Bottom Left): This is your "media bin." It stores all your video clips, audio files, graphics, and sequences. It does not hold the video itself; it holds links to the files on your hard drive.

The Source Monitor (Top Left): This is where you preview your raw clips before adding them to the timeline. This is where you set In and Out points.

The Program Monitor (Top Right): This is your "canvas." It shows you the active timeline playing in real-time. This is what the final viewer will see.

The Timeline (Bottom Right): This is the "cutting floor." This is where you arrange clips, trim them, and add effects.

B. Creating a New Project:

Go to File > New > Project.

Name your project.

Browse to choose where to save it (choose a fast drive if possible).

Important: Under the "Scratch Disks" tab, set your Video/Audio Previews and Captures to "Same as Project" to keep all files in one folder.

C. Creating a Sequence (The Timeline):

A Sequence is essentially your "canvas" settings (resolution and frame rate).

Quick Method: Drag a clip from the Project Panel directly onto the "New Item" icon (the folded paper icon at the bottom of the Project Panel). Premiere will automatically match the sequence settings to your clip. This is usually the best choice.

Pro Tip: Save your workspace layout by going to Window > Workspaces > Save as New Workspace. Name it "My Edit."

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2. IMPORTING & ORGANIZING MEDIA

Organization is the secret to fast editing. If you can't find a clip, you lose time.

A. How to Import:

Method 1: File > Import (Shortcut: Cmd+I on Mac / Ctrl+I on Windows).

Method 2: Double-click anywhere in the empty space of the Project Panel.

Method 3: Drag and drop files directly from your computer's desktop into the Project Panel.

B. The "Bin" System (Folders):

Create Bins (folders) inside the Project Panel to structure your media. A standard structure looks like this:

1_SEQUENCES (Place your main timeline here)

2_VIDEO (Raw footage)

3_AUDIO (Music and Sound FX)

4_GRAPHICS (Logos, Lower Thirds)

5_EXPORTS (For final renders)

C. Essential Preview Tools:

Hover Scrub: Hover your mouse over a clip in the Project Panel and drag left/right to preview it quickly.

In/Out Points: Double-click a clip to open it in the Source Monitor. Hit the I key to mark an "In" point (start) and the O key to mark an "Out" point (end). This tells Premiere you only want to use that specific section of the clip.

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3. THE CUT (ASSEMBLY & TRIM)

This is the "Rough Cut" phase. You are slapping the story together in order.

A. Getting Video to the Timeline:

Insert Edit (V key then Click + Drag): Drag a clip from the Source Monitor to the Timeline. If you drop it in the middle of existing clips, everything shifts to the right to make room. (Good for inserting B-roll).

Overwrite Edit (Drag while holding Ctrl/Cmd): This places the clip on the timeline, but replaces whatever is in that spot. (Good for replacing a bad take).

The , (Comma) Shortcut: While the Source Monitor is active, simply press the , key to add the clip to the end of your timeline.

B. The Three Essential Tools (Keyboard Shortcuts):

Selection Tool (V): Your default arrow. Use it to click, drag, and select clips.

Razor Tool (C): Cuts clips. Click on a clip in the timeline to slice it into two pieces.

Track Select Tool (A): Selects everything to the right of where you click. Great for moving large chunks of your timeline around.

C. Basic Trimming (Precision):

Ripple Trim (B then drag): If you drag the edge of a clip, it cuts the clip and automatically closes the gap for you. This is the "Hollywood" edit—no empty spaces left behind.

Rolling Edit (N then drag): Drag the cut point between two clips. It makes Clip A longer and Clip B shorter without changing the total duration.

Pro Tip: Stop using the Razor Tool so much. Instead, use the "Extract" feature: Select a part of a clip with the Mark In (I) and Mark Out (O) keys, then press the ' (Apostrophe) key to remove that section and close the gap automatically.

4. AUDIO, TRANSITIONS & EFFECTS

A. Audio Essentials (The "Hidden Gem"):

Audio Track Mixer: Go to Window > Audio Track Mixer. Here you can adjust the volume of entire tracks (like lowering all music tracks at once).

Keyframes (Volume): Click the thin line on an audio clip in the timeline to create a keyframe. Drag it down to lower the volume. This is how you "duck" music when someone is speaking.

Audio Gain: Right-click a clip and select Audio Gain. Set it to -3dB or -6dB to ensure you have enough "headroom" (space) before the audio distorts.

B. Video Transitions:

The Rule: Use them sparingly.

The Default: A "Cross Dissolve" is the standard fade to black or fade between clips. Go to the Effects Panel > Video Transitions > Dissolve > Cross Dissolve.

Shortcut: Drag the transition to the edge of a clip, or select the cut point and press Cmd+D (Mac) or Ctrl+D (Windows) to apply the default transition (which you can set to Cross Dissolve).

C. Applying Effects (Color & Stabilization):

Lumetri Color (Color Grading): Go to Effects > Video Effects > Color Correction > Lumetri Color. Drag it onto your clip. In the "Effect Controls" panel, you will find sliders for:

Basic Correction: Set your White Balance and Exposure.

Curves: For contrast and "S-Curves" (highlights and shadows).

Vignette: Darken the edges to draw focus to the subject.

Warp Stabilizer: Drag it onto shaky footage. In the Effect Controls, set "Result" to Smooth Motion and "Method" to Subspace Warp. (Note: This takes time to render).

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5. EXPORTING & SHORTCUTS CHEAT SHEET

A. Exporting (The Final Step):

Go to File > Export > Media (Shortcut: Cmd+M / Ctrl+M).

Format: Choose H.264. This is the universal standard for web sharing.

Preset: Choose "YouTube 1080p HD" or "Vimeo 1080p HD". These are optimized presets.

Bitrate Settings: Under the "Video" tab, scroll to "Bitrate Settings."

VBR (Variable Bitrate), 2 Pass: This gives the best quality for the smallest file size.

Target Bitrate: Set to 10 Mbps for HD; 16 Mbps for 4K.

Render: Click the "Queue" button (not "Export"). This sends the job to Adobe Media Encoder, which allows you to keep editing in Premiere while it exports in the background.

B. QUICK REFERENCE: THE KEYBOARD SHORTCUTS

Action Shortcut (Mac/PC) Why It's Useful

Select Tool V Moving things around.

Razor (Cut) C Slicing clips.

Ripple Trim B Removing gaps when trimming.

Add Edit (Cut) Cmd+K / Ctrl+K Cuts the clip exactly where the playhead is. (Faster than Razor).

Mark In I Start of the section you want.

Mark Out O End of the section you want.

Insert , (Comma) Add selected clip to timeline.

Overwrite . (Period) Replace clip on timeline.

Export Cmd+M / Ctrl+M Open the Export window.

Undo Cmd+Z / Ctrl+Z Fix mistakes. (Your best friend).

C. The Golden Rule of Premiere Pro

"Garbage In, Garbage Out." If the lighting and audio are bad on set, no editing trick will save it. Always organize your files before you start cutting, and remember to save your project frequently (Cmd+S / Ctrl+S). Happy editing!